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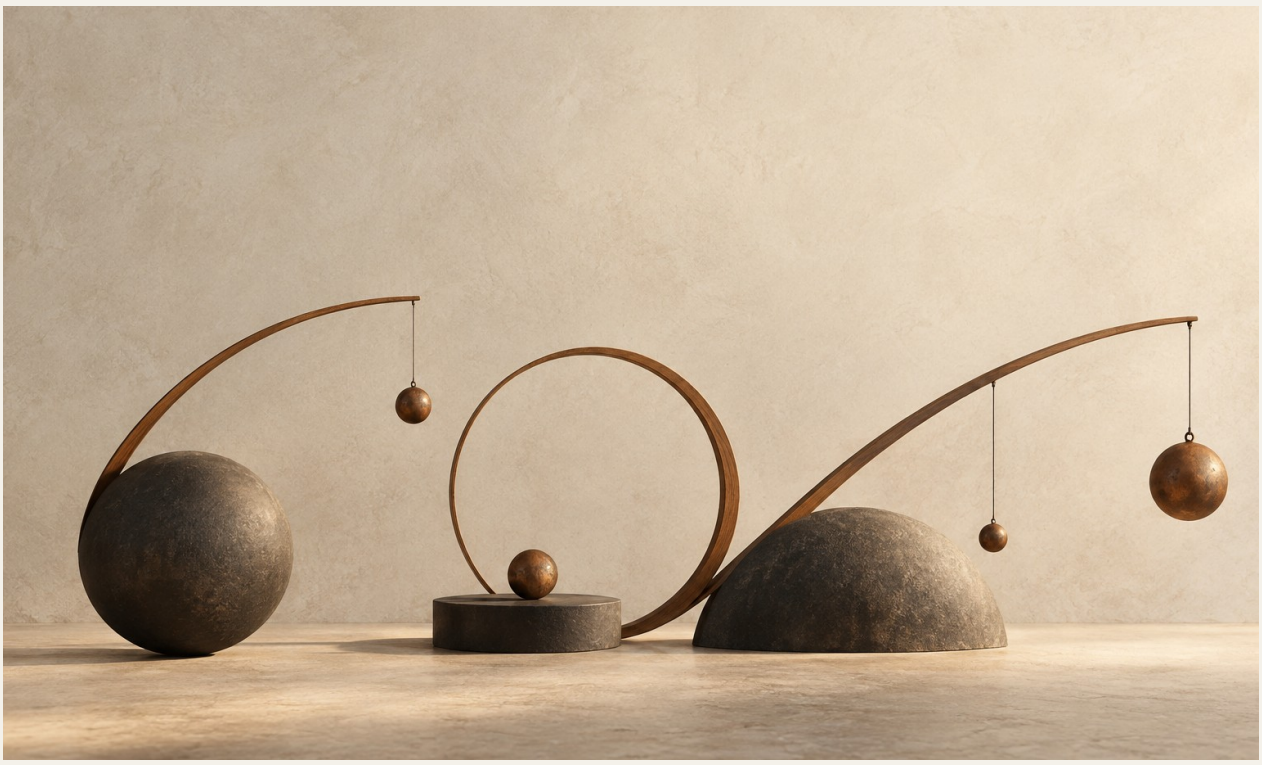
Weight and motion

Animals as Leaders, new recordings and the arrangements that keep movement audible.

Ze Xun Lai | 賴則勳

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Weight, motion and the choices that make a crowded phrase audible.

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Weight and motion

Animals as Leaders is this issue’s close reading, not its entire horizon. The trio makes a useful question audible: when a fast arrangement arrives with several possible centres, how does a listener keep track of its direction? The answer lies in changing responsibility between parts, not in virtuosity alone.

> A dense phrase survives when its weight has somewhere else to go.

That question needs contrast. This issue moves from Meshuggah and Battles to Dawn of Midi, Hella, Horse Lords, black midi, Elephant Gym and Kayo Dot. Each asks an instrument to carry time, contour or texture in a different way. No one record supplies a single correct measure of precision.

The feature stays with Animals as Leaders and names its limits. The new-music pages turn to Entheos, Cult of Luna, Oren Ambarchi, Swans, The Dear Hunter and The Operator Sound INC. The live page watches an official filmed performance. The instrument pages put three Abasi designs in their actual material and buying conditions.

A moving centre

Criticism begins with what a recording makes available to the ear: a recurring attack, a changed register, a withheld entrance or a body of sound that suddenly makes room. Where a score, credit or public source cannot settle the claim, this issue says so. The work is to hear carefully, not to make complexity look measurable.

Eight records with room to breathe

Meshuggah

Bleed

2008



Meshuggah · Bleed · official video

Meshuggah · official music video

Bleed gives repetition a body. Its insistence is less a puzzle than an agreement between a low guitar figure, kick-drum force and a listener’s ability to locate the next return. The track stays severe because it does not soften the pressure that defines it.

Official listening · YouTube

Artist and release reference

Battles

Atlas

2007



Battles · Atlas · official video

Battles · official music video

Atlas lets short figures behave like moving architecture. Guitar, drums and processed vocal fragments do not compete for the same dramatic role; they pass propulsion from one surface to another. The pleasure is in hearing a system remain playful without becoming vague.

Official listening · YouTube

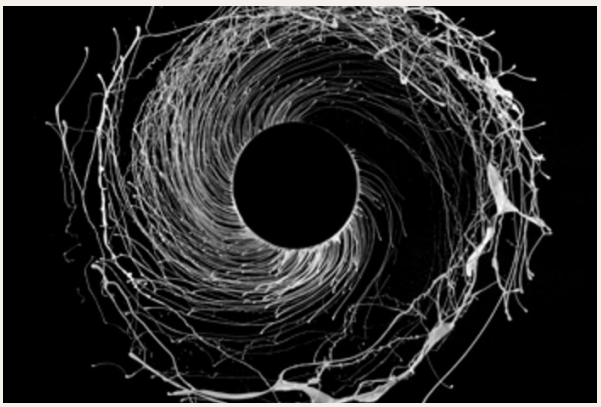
Artist and release reference

A pattern can stay open

Dawn of Midi

Io

2015



Dawn of Midi · Dysnomia · official release

Dawn of Midi · official release page

Io treats piano, bass and drums as a single machine with three different textures. Its appeal is not an illusion of mechanical perfection. Small changes in articulation keep the pattern human, while the ensemble’s restraint gives each attack a clear edge.

Official listening · YouTube

Artist and release reference

Hella

Biblical Violence

2007



Hella · Biblical Violence · official release

Hella · official release page

Biblical Violence makes speed feel conversational because the guitar and drums keep revising the ground beneath one another. Its volatility is structural. A phrase does not settle long enough to become a display of skill; it has to keep finding its footing.

Official listening · YouTube

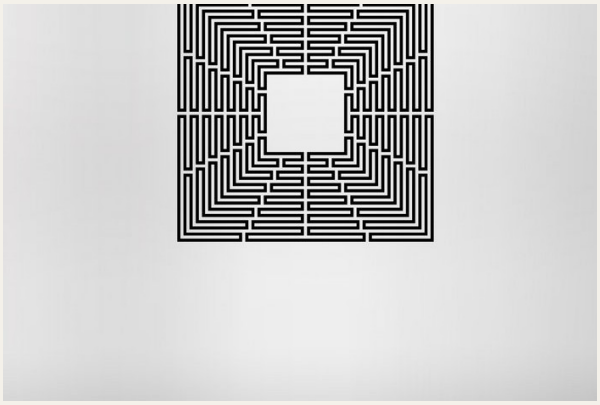
Artist and release reference

The edge of a phrase

Horse Lords

Outer East

2020



Horse Lords · official release

Horse Lords · official release page

Outer East treats tuning, repetition and ensemble balance as one question. The material gains force from how little it insists on a single foreground. Motion comes from the relation between parts, and that relation is allowed to stay slightly unstable.

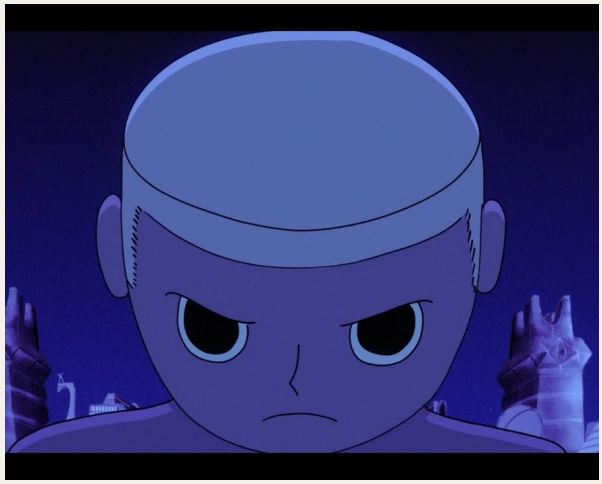
Official listening · YouTube

Artist and release reference

black midi

John L

2021



black midi · John L · official video

black midi · official music video

John L makes its changes audible by exaggerating their edges. Brass, voice, guitar and drums arrive as characters with different densities, then are cut apart before they become scenery. The song’s disorder works because each rupture resets the listener’s orientation.

Official listening · YouTube

Artist and release reference

A line can carry the room

Elephant Gym

Wings

2022



Elephant Gym · official artist image

Elephant Gym · official artist source

Wings gives the bass a melodic responsibility without asking the rest of the arrangement to retreat. Its lines remain buoyant because drums and guitar draw a light frame around them. The result is density with a visible centre of gravity.

A low line can lead without taking every available space.

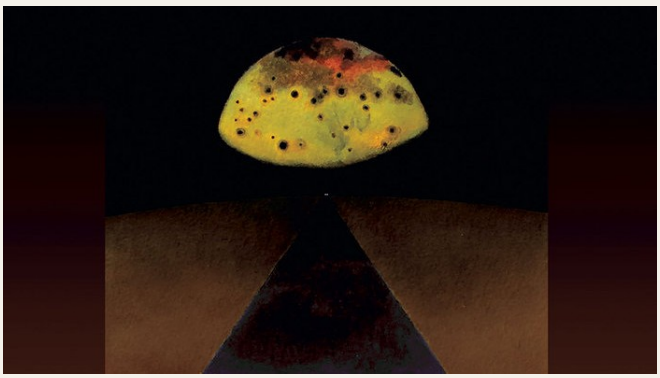
Official listening · YouTube

Artist and release reference

Kayo Dot

The Mortality of Doves

2024



Kayo Dot · Doves · official release

Kayo Dot · official release page

The Mortality of Doves treats arrangement as a series of altered thresholds. Timbres do not merely colour a stable song; they change what kind of song the listener is inside. Its shifts matter because the work lets each new surface keep a trace of the last.

A change of texture can also change the scale of time.

Official listening · YouTube

Artist and release reference

Technique becomes relation

Three players, shifting obligations

Animals as Leaders is made of Tosin Abasi and Javier Reyes on guitars with Matt Garstka on drums. A useful analysis begins by naming changing obligations rather than declaring a passage difficult. One part may establish a recurring attack, another may redirect the register, and the kit may make a return feel either grounded or suspended.

Hear the attack before naming the metre

The Problem of Other Minds can be approached through audible events: follow the recurring attack, listen for the drum response, then notice when a guitar sound behaves less like a line and more like percussion. This is a listening method, not a transcription. Without a published score or bar-by-bar verification, fine metric labels remain provisional.

The record is allowed to exceed the stage

The official video gives the work another body: camera movement, choreography and edited space create a form beside the recording. That does not prove a technical fact about the music. It does show why arrangement matters: a dense work stays intelligible when entries, registers and physical gestures are given different kinds of attention.



Animals as Leaders, The Problem of Other Minds, official music video. The feature begins with audible attack and changing register.

Feature references · official video, artist source and listening route

Pulse meets its return

Pulse differs from grouping

Pulse is the repeatable reference a listener can tap; grouping is the way attacks are organised inside that reference. Four equal spans can coexist with a 3+3+2 attack shape, and an eight-unit figure can carry accents that miss the drummer’s larger return. Calling all of this “odd metre” hides the central question: which recurrence gives the phrase its orientation?

Return, coincidence and LCM

Let u be the shortest stable attack unit chosen for one listening pass. If a figure occupies 8u and a neighbouring figure repeats every 5u, the next shared restart is LCM(8, 5) = 40u. This is an analytic model, not a claim that The Problem of Other Minds uses that exact pattern. It makes one question repeatable: why can two figures feel independent before a common centre returns?

Three names, three claims

Polyrhythm describes rates within one span; polymeter describes concurrent cycles of different lengths; additive grouping describes an ordered partition such as 3+3+2. One label does not prove the others. First tap the most stable pulse, then mark attacks, then compare the next common return. If following another layer changes the result, record the ambiguity instead of forcing a single grid.



Animals as Leaders, Parrhesia (2022). Official album cover.

Animals as Leaders · official album page

The anatomy of attack

Describe an event before a category

A listening note can name an event e = (t, r, a, d): onset time, register, attack profile and perceived decay. It is not a recording measurement. Equal pitches can take different structural roles when one arrives sharply, another blooms late, or a low sound remains after a high figure has gone.

Register and decay change function

A regular low-guitar onset may act as pulse; decay that crosses the next event may become weight. A high line can read as melody when contour persists, then as percussion when articulation outruns pitch memory. Function belongs to what a sound changes in the next expectation, not permanently to guitar or drums.

Role comes before hierarchy

Trace a recurring attack and ask who changes its weight, height or available space. The answer can move inside one phrase, without a solo or fixed leader. No published score, bar-by-bar transcription, tempo claim or key claim is implied.

Repeatable disagreement is evidence

A second listener should repeat the count, disagree about its grouping and identify where the evidence changes. Name the pulse, attack unit and return point before offering a conclusion.



Animals as Leaders, The Joy of Motion (2014). Official album cover.

Animals as Leaders · official album page

New work tests the frame

Entheos

Empty on the Inside

23 OCTOBER 2026

Entheos frame their forthcoming record as a release that arrives with two tracks already public. The useful opening is not a claim about difficulty; it is the relation between tightly articulated attack and a vocal line that refuses to become merely decorative. The arrangement keeps tension active by giving every return a changed edge.

Official release · Bandcamp

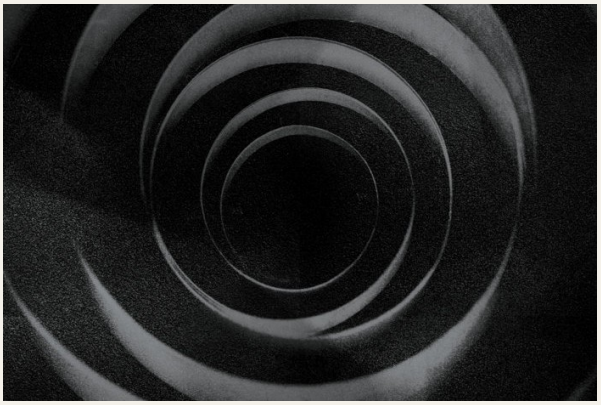
Release reference

> An attack means something when its phrase can change.

Cult of Luna

In the Shadow of Your Shadow

06 NOVEMBER 2026



Cult of Luna · official release

Cult of Luna · official release page

Cult of Luna’s official release page presents a long-form record whose individual pieces need patience rather than compression. In this context, scale is not simply loudness. It is the time a work gives a texture before it asks that texture to bear a new emotional role.

Official release · Bandcamp

Official artist source

Release reference

Four further pressures

Oren Ambarchi

Prophetic Perfect Tense

23 OCTOBER 2026

Ambarchi’s forthcoming solo-guitar release is presented as two long takes recorded with minimal effects. That premise shifts attention from accumulation to duration: what does a guitar sound reveal when its material is allowed to persist instead of being cut into a sequence of solutions?

Official release · Bandcamp

Release reference

> A long form needs a reason to remain present.

Swans

Newly Sentient Being

02 OCTOBER 2026



Swans · official release

Swans · official release page

Newly Sentient Being documents an extended live performance rather than reducing it to a souvenir. Its length is part of the proposition: the listener has time to hear mass accumulate, disperse and return. The release asks for patience as an active form of attention.

Official release · Bandcamp

Release reference

A voice can carry a world

The Dear Hunter

Sunya

20 MARCH 2026



The Dear Hunter · official artist image

The Dear Hunter · official artist source

Sunya makes scope legible through recurring narrative and instrumental cues. Its large-scale ambition works when a new colour changes a scene rather than simply announcing a bigger moment. The record gives the listener handles, then lets those handles move.

Official artist source

Release reference

The Operator Sound INC.

Esoteric Audio for Spaceage Witchcraft

02 OCTOBER 2026



The Operator Sound INC. · official release

The Operator Sound INC. · official release page

The Operator Sound INC. works with modular synthesis, organ and rhythm boxes, but the point is not retro display. A limited palette makes small shifts in tone, density and timing legible. It is a compact counterexample to the belief that experimental music must continually add material.

Official release · Bandcamp

Release reference

A filmed body changes the question

Animals as Leaders

The Problem of Other Minds · Official video

17 NOVEMBER 2021
Official music video · YouTube



Animals as Leaders performing The Woven Web. Live performance image.

Washed Up Media · live performance image

The filmed version does not verify an analytical diagram. It gives the music a second choreography: bodies, cuts and changing distances lead the eye through an arrangement whose recorded layers cannot be reduced to a single visual cause. Watch where attention moves when the recurring attack returns.

Recorded density

Filmed direction

A recording can distribute responsibility among several tracks. A video chooses where a viewer is allowed to look. The two forms do not duplicate one another; each clarifies what the other does not.

Official video · YouTube

Before you press play

Begin with the recording, then watch the official video. Notice whether your attention follows an individual gesture or the changing relation among gestures. That movement is part of the work’s form.

Animals as Leaders · official channel

Instruments place a hand in the form

Three Abasi models, three boundaries

An instrument is not a neutral container for technique. Scale length, string spacing, body balance and pickup response change the distances a hand covers and the resistance it meets. These facts do not guarantee better music. They specify what a player can test, repeat and decline. This chapter separates documented specifications from editorial judgement.



Larada 8 Master Series / Sage. Official product image. Abasi Concepts · official maker image

Larada 8 Master Series / Sage

The maker page listed the Larada 8 Master Series / Sage at USD 3,999 when checked on 18 October 2026. It specifies a 25.5–27.5 inch multi-scale layout, individual saddles, locking tuners and Tosin Abasi Fishman Fluence pickups. Its relevant question is not prestige but whether a player needs low-register tension and string separation in a real repertoire.

Official maker store · USD 3,999 · checked 18 OCT 2026



Larada 8 Master Series / Sage. Official product image. Abasi Concepts · official maker image

Price is not the decision

Fit and intended role

A Larada 8 needs a physical trial wherever possible: reach, neck position, multiscale response and string spacing are bodily facts, not a product-page conclusion. An artist association cannot answer those questions on behalf of a player.

Buying conditions



Córdoba | Abasi Stage 7. Official product image.
Abasi Concepts · official maker image

Córdoba | Abasi Stage 7

The Stage 7 is a seven-string nylon electric design intended for an electric player’s physical vocabulary. The maker describes a chambered body, narrow spacing, twenty-four frets and a custom Fishman system. Its value proposition is specific: nylon response without requiring a player to abandon familiar movement.

Official maker page · product details



Córdoba | Abasi Stage 7. Official product image.
Abasi Concepts · official maker image

Ēmi 7 Master Series / Tundra

The Ēmi 7 Master Series / Tundra was listed at USD 3,899 on the US maker collection when checked on 18 October 2026. A seven-string platform defines a more bounded low register than the Larada 8. That is a use case, not a hierarchy: a writing practice may need extension without needing the reach of eight strings.

Official maker collection · USD 3,899 · checked 18 OCT 2026



Ēmi 7 Master Series. Official product image.

Abasi Concepts · official maker image

What must be checked before a purchase

All three listings use direct US maker routes. Published prices do not establish a Taiwan landed cost, and small-batch stock can change. Confirm freight, taxes, service access, warranty terms, return conditions and physical fit before treating a listed price as a decision point.

Dates in the room

wave to earth

24 NOVEMBER 2026 · TUESDAY

wave to earth bring the pieces tour to Taipei International Convention Center. The official listing places the concert on a large seated stage, with ticket prices announced from NTD 2,300 to 6,300. Treat the listed range as a current route, not as a guarantee of availability; entry terms and remaining inventory belong to the promoter’s live page.

Official event information

DOMi & JD BECK

04 DECEMBER 2026 · FRIDAY

DOMi & JD BECK are listed for Clapper Studio on the WHO ASKED? Tour. A small-room bill changes the question asked of rhythm: the relevant information is venue scale, start time, access and the presenter’s update trail. It does not predict a set list, but it gives a listener a real place to hear the music.

Official event information

Slowdive

10 DECEMBER 2026 · THURSDAY

Slowdive are scheduled for Zepp New Taipei through the current presenter listing. The date belongs in a weekly magazine because venue, route and local audience alter a performance’s condition; they do not turn an announcement into criticism. Confirm final doors, ticket availability and venue instructions with the presenter.

Official event information

A calendar makes commitments visible

Dates do not prove a critical judgment. They make the practical conditions of listening visible: a room, a promoter, a ticket route, a door time and a changing stock of access. These details let a recording meet a local audience in public. They cannot tell us whether a performance will be good, and they should never be used to pretend that they can. A ticket price describes a transaction rather than artistic value; a venue capacity does not describe musical scale. Yet both details establish the practical pressure under which a concert is encountered, including whose time, travel and attention the event asks for.

A date is not a forecast

The calendar treats official listings as evidence of a proposed encounter, not as a substitute for listening. Promoter pages, ticket platforms and venue notices can change after publication. Each entry therefore identifies a route to check, while the criticism elsewhere in this issue remains grounded in work that can be heard, seen or documented. No StreetVoice material is used. This distinction protects the reader from a familiar mistake: treating an announced event, an official channel and a critical judgment as if they were the same kind of claim. They are not. The calendar states what is scheduled and where it can be checked; the feature and review pages must account for how they listen.

Images and sources

Images

Official images; TMFD cover and contents art
Source / editorial basis

Animals as Leaders · official video · editorial citation
Source / editorial basis

Abasi Concepts · official maker images
Source / editorial basis

TMFD · recognisable cover and contents art
Source / editorial basis

Official images · full source ledger
Source / editorial basis

Interior images match named subjects
Source / editorial basis

Animals as Leaders · official video · editorial citation
Source / editorial basis

Abasi Concepts · Larada 8 Master Series image
Source / editorial basis

Abasi Concepts · Stage 7 image
Source / editorial basis

Abasi Concepts · Ēmi 7 Master Series image
Source / editorial basis

Sources and crops retained in ledger
Source / editorial basis

No generic filler graphics are used.
Source / editorial basis

Sources verified 18 October 2026.
Source / editorial basis

Primary references

Animals as Leaders · official video, artist source and Parrhesia information

Entheos, Cult of Luna and Oren Ambarchi · official release pages

Swans, The Dear Hunter and The Operator Sound INC. · official release pages

Abasi Concepts and Córdoba · official maker pages

Live Nation Taiwan · wave to earth and DOMi & JD BECK listings; ULC · Slowdive listing

Meshuggah, Battles, Dawn of Midi, Hella and Horse Lords · official listening routes

black midi, Elephant Gym and Kayo Dot · official listening routes

Information verified 18 October 2026; availability, prices and event details can change.

Direct-maker prices are not Taiwan landed costs.

Listening links and evidence links are kept distinct.

No StreetVoice material was used in this issue.